



FITNESSWISE

Ramji Srinivasan



FOR MORE
STORIES

TAPERING DONE RIGHT: THE FOUNDATION BEHIND PEAK PERFORMANCE

From fatigue management to load reduction, here's how athletes can **customise tapering** for optimal results.

In one of my earlier articles, I wrote about the benefits of tapering and other research protocols. Now we continue with the foundation of tapering and the science behind it. Many times, the recipe is contradictory to the concoction that turns out.

Tapering, which is a form of planned reduction in training volume before a major event, thrives because it solves snags previously created — having accumulated more training load than one could tolerate, which first leads to fatigue and later a drop in performance.

It is possible that, for specific competitions, one needs to accumulate more work in the preceding weeks to provide a stronger stimulus, knowing that you will recuperate through tapering protocols.

The duration of the taper is directly proportional to the degree of accumulated fatigue over a period of time. This must be identified ahead of time. If thoroughly exhausted, one needs a longer tapering process. If, on the other hand, one is in good shape, it will be enough to ease off slightly a few days before the competition.

Overdoing the load in the previous week could lead to a prolonged tapering process, which, in turn, can affect adaptation, recovery, and skill. One must be mindful in designing the regime in tandem with the important competition. Training too hard under the pretext of a severe session for neural priming is a huge mistake in the tapering process.

The target of tapering is to train to a lesser extent than you are able to recover from, allowing the body to regenerate after previous fatigue, while at the same time trying to maintain the adaptations achieved earlier.

The method usually involves reducing volume while maintaining intensity. High-intensity training (VO₂ max pace, for example) generates a very systemic stimulus that helps maintain aerobic and glycolytic adaptations.

In contrast, if we only work on aerobic capacity, we will not generate a substantial stimulus for aerobic power or for the glycolytic pathway.

Neuromuscular adaptations related to strength and power do not reverse in one or two weeks, which is why they are not heavily emphasised above, although some cues can be included during the tapering period if competitions continue throughout the year.

However, you should keep in mind that this advice to reduce volume is